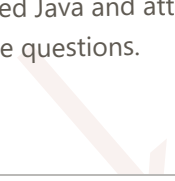


Selection Sort

Learn how finding the smallest remaining value fixes one position at a time.

How to use this chapter:

Learn the idea in plain language, read each diagram, predict every trace row, then study the commented Java and attempt the exam-style questions.



Start with the idea

Selection sort fills the row from left to right. Scan the unfinished part to find its smallest value, then swap that value into the position you are filling. A swap exchanges two values' positions.

A small example

Fill the first position in [29, 72, 98, 13, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36].

Begin with 29 as the smallest value seen so far. Check 72 and 98; neither is smaller.

In the next illustration, follow the smallest value found during each scan, then the exchange into the next open position. The finished section grows from the left.

The whole process at a glance

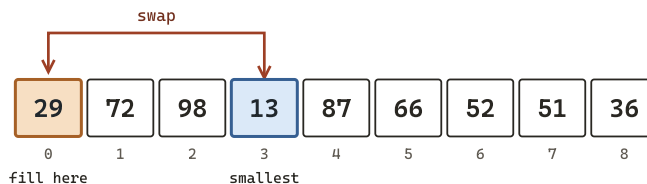
Read down the page. In each pass, find the smallest value in the unfinished part, then swap it into the next position on the left. Leave the green completed positions alone.

Green: sorted

Blue: being checked

Orange: position to fill

Pass 1: fill index 0



Start with [29, 72, 98, 13, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]. Fill index 0; remember 29 at index 0 as the smallest seen so far.

Check 72 at index 1: $72 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

Check 98 at index 2: $98 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

Check 13 at index 3: $13 < 29$ is true. Remember 13 at index 3 as the new smallest.

Check 87 at index 4: $87 < 13$ is false. Keep 13 as the smallest.

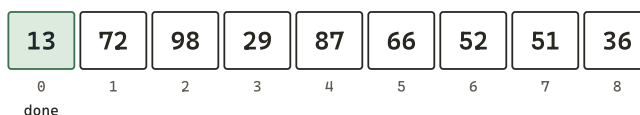
Check 66 at index 5: $66 < 13$ is false. Keep 13 as the smallest.

Check 52 at index 6: $52 < 13$ is false. Keep 13 as the smallest.

Check 51 at index 7: $51 < 13$ is false. Keep 13 as the smallest.

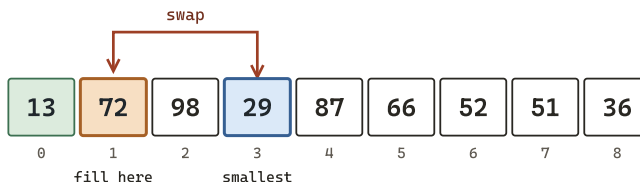
Check 36 at index 8: $36 < 13$ is false. Keep 13 as the smallest.

The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value is 13 at index 3. Swap 29 and 13 to fill index 0.



The row is now [13, 72, 98, 29, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]. Position 0 is finished. 29 takes the position that 13 left behind. Next, fill index 1: start with 72 as the smallest and scan from index 2.

Pass 2: fill index 1



Start with [13, 72, 98, 29, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]. Fill index 1; remember 72 at index 1 as the smallest seen so far.

Check 98 at index 2: $98 < 72$ is false. Keep 72 as the smallest.

Check 29 at index 3: $29 < 72$ is true. Remember 29 at index 3 as the new smallest.

Check 87 at index 4: $87 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

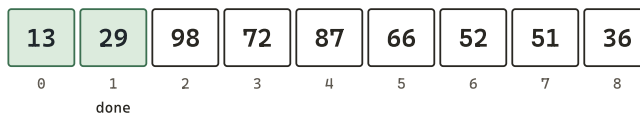
Check 66 at index 5: $66 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

Check 52 at index 6: $52 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

Check 51 at index 7: $51 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

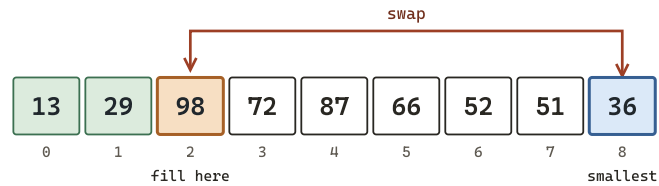
Check 36 at index 8: $36 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value is 29 at index 3. Swap 72 and 29 to fill index 1.



The row is now [13, 29, 98, 72, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]. Position 1 is finished. 72 takes the position that 29 left behind. Next, fill index 2: start with 98 as the smallest and scan from index 3.

Pass 3: fill index 2



Start with [13, 29, 98, 72, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]. Fill index 2; remember 98 at index 2 as the smallest seen so far.

Check 72 at index 3: $72 < 98$ is true. Remember 72 at index 3 as the new smallest.

Check 87 at index 4: $87 < 72$ is false. Keep 72 as the smallest.

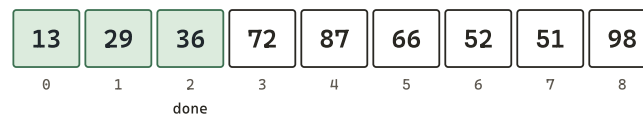
Check 66 at index 5: $66 < 72$ is true. Remember 66 at index 5 as the new smallest.

Check 52 at index 6: $52 < 66$ is true. Remember 52 at index 6 as the new smallest.

Check 51 at index 7: $51 < 52$ is true. Remember 51 at index 7 as the new smallest.

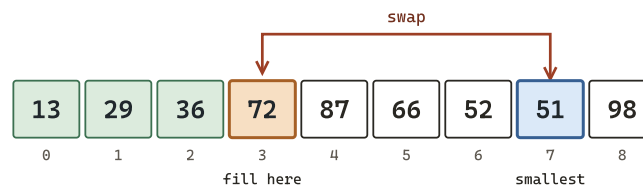
Check 36 at index 8: $36 < 51$ is true. Remember 36 at index 8 as the new smallest.

The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value is 36 at index 8. Swap 98 and 36 to fill index 2.



The row is now [13, 29, 36, 72, 87, 66, 52, 51, 98]. Position 2 is finished. 98 takes the position that 36 left behind. Next, fill index 3: start with 72 as the smallest and scan from index 4.

Pass 4: fill index 3



Start with [13, 29, 36, 72, 87, 66, 52, 51, 98]. Fill index 3; remember 72 at index 3 as the smallest seen so far.

Check 87 at index 4: $87 < 72$ is false. Keep 72 as the smallest.

Check 66 at index 5: $66 < 72$ is true. Remember 66 at index 5 as the new smallest.

Check 52 at index 6: $52 < 66$ is true. Remember 52 at index 6 as the new smallest.

Check 51 at index 7: $51 < 52$ is true. Remember 51 at index 7 as the new smallest.

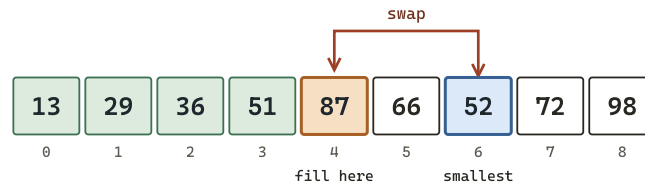
Check 98 at index 8: $98 < 51$ is false. Keep 51 as the smallest.

The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value is 51 at index 7. Swap 72 and 51 to fill index 3.



The row is now [13, 29, 36, 51, 87, 66, 52, 72, 98]. Position 3 is finished. 72 takes the position that 51 left behind. Next, fill index 4: start with 87 as the smallest and scan from index 5.

Pass 5: fill index 4



Start with [13, 29, 36, 51, 87, 66, 52, 72, 98]. Fill index 4; remember 87 at index 4 as the smallest seen so far.

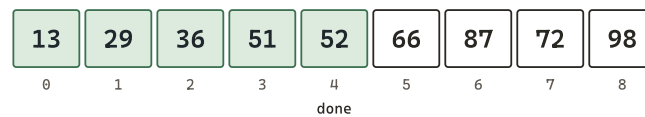
Check 66 at index 5: $66 < 87$ is true. Remember 66 at index 5 as the new smallest.

Check 52 at index 6: $52 < 66$ is true. Remember 52 at index 6 as the new smallest.

Check 72 at index 7: $72 < 52$ is false. Keep 52 as the smallest.

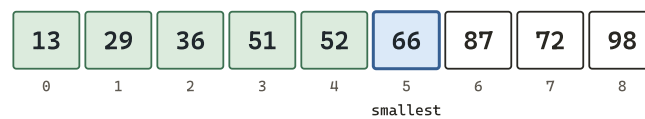
Check 98 at index 8: $98 < 52$ is false. Keep 52 as the smallest.

The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value is 52 at index 6. Swap 87 and 52 to fill index 4.



The row is now [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 87, 72, 98]. Position 4 is finished. 87 takes the position that 52 left behind. Next, fill index 5: start with 66 as the smallest and scan from index 6.

Pass 6: fill index 5



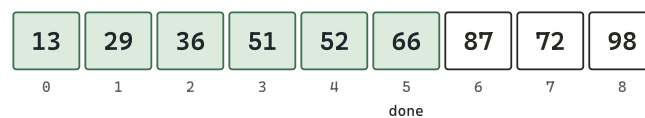
Start with [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 87, 72, 98]. Fill index 5; remember 66 at index 5 as the smallest seen so far.

Check 87 at index 6: $87 < 66$ is false. Keep 66 as the smallest.

Check 72 at index 7: $72 < 66$ is false. Keep 66 as the smallest.

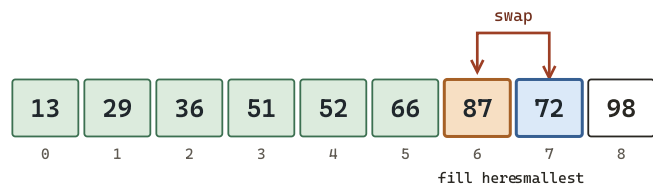
Check 98 at index 8: $98 < 66$ is false. Keep 66 as the smallest.

The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value, 66, is already at index 5. Leave it there.



The row is now [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 87, 72, 98]. Position 5 is finished. No swap was needed. Next, fill index 6: start with 87 as the smallest and scan from index 7.

Pass 7: fill index 6

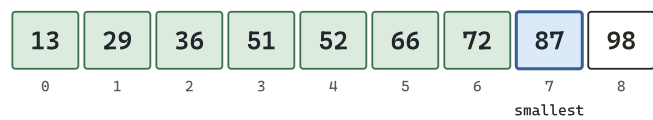


Start with [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 87, 72, 98]. Fill index 6; remember 87 at index 6 as the smallest seen so far.
Check 72 at index 7: $72 < 87$ is true. Remember 72 at index 7 as the new smallest.
Check 98 at index 8: $98 < 72$ is false. Keep 72 as the smallest.
The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value is 72 at index 7. Swap 87 and 72 to fill index 6.

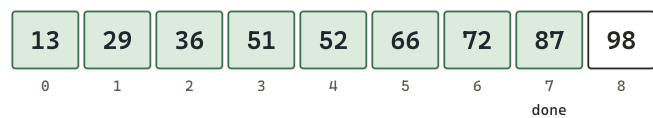


The row is now [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 72, 87, 98]. Position 6 is finished. 87 takes the position that 72 left behind. Next, fill index 7: start with 87 as the smallest and scan from index 8.

Pass 8: fill index 7



Start with [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 72, 87, 98]. Fill index 7; remember 87 at index 7 as the smallest seen so far.
Check 98 at index 8: $98 < 87$ is false. Keep 87 as the smallest.
The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value, 87, is already at index 7. Leave it there.



The row is now [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 72, 87, 98]. Position 7 is finished. No swap was needed. Only the last position remains; its value is already in place, so stop.

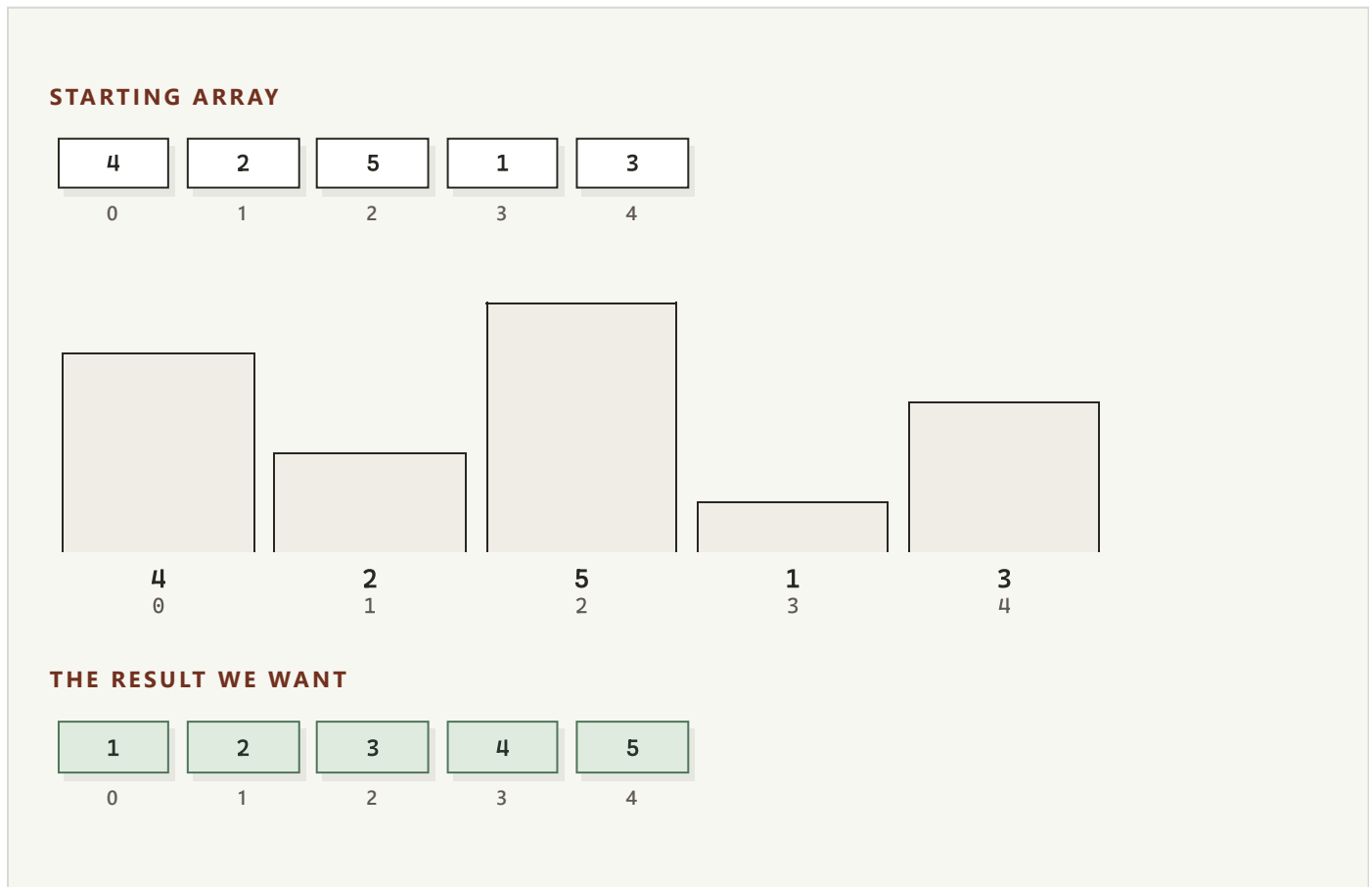
Sorted: [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 72, 87, 98]. Once all earlier positions are filled, the last remaining value is already in place.

The array we will sort

Detailed reference example: this part introduces its own input, shown below. The opening whole-run map and guided walkthrough keep their original input throughout; each later worked example states its new input explicitly.

The array we will sort

The same five values again: $[4, 2, 5, 1, 3]$, sorted from smallest to largest.



It is the same array that bubble sort and insertion sort use, so you can compare the three methods on identical data. One value deserves attention: the 1 is the smallest and sits at index 3. Bubble sort moves it one place per pass. Selection sort will find it and move it to the front **in a single swap**.

Why this works

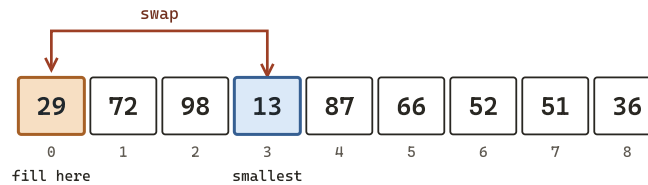
Waiting until the scan ends confirms that no smaller value remains. On the next pass, leave 13 alone and search the rest. If the smallest value is already in the position being filled, leave it there; no swap is needed.

Guided walkthrough: predict the next major step

Predict the next completed pass, then advance. Each scene keeps all its movements together.

Guided walkthrough: major steps

Pass 1: fill index 0



Start with [29, 72, 98, 13, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]. Fill index 0; remember 29 at index 0 as the smallest seen so far.

Check 72 at index 1: $72 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

Check 98 at index 2: $98 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

Check 13 at index 3: $13 < 29$ is true. Remember 13 at index 3 as the new smallest.

Check 87 at index 4: $87 < 13$ is false. Keep 13 as the smallest.

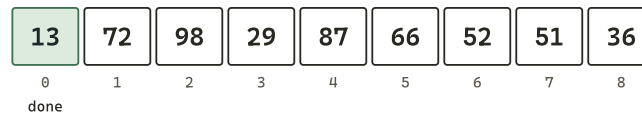
Check 66 at index 5: $66 < 13$ is false. Keep 13 as the smallest.

Check 52 at index 6: $52 < 13$ is false. Keep 13 as the smallest.

Check 51 at index 7: $51 < 13$ is false. Keep 13 as the smallest.

Check 36 at index 8: $36 < 13$ is false. Keep 13 as the smallest.

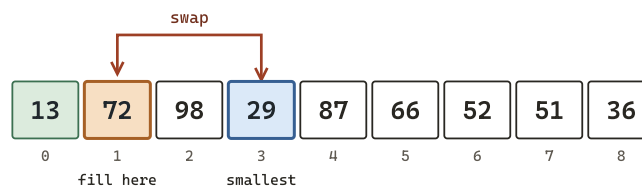
The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value is 13 at index 3. Swap 29 and 13 to fill index 0.



The row is now [13, 72, 98, 29, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]. Position 0 is finished. 29 takes the position that 13 left behind. Next, fill index 1: start with 72 as the smallest and scan from index 2.

The smallest remaining value is 13 at index 3. Swap 29 and 13 to fill index 0.

Pass 2: fill index 1



Start with [13, 72, 98, 29, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]. Fill index 1; remember 72 at index 1 as the smallest seen so far.

Check 98 at index 2: $98 < 72$ is false. Keep 72 as the smallest.

Check 29 at index 3: $29 < 72$ is true. Remember 29 at index 3 as the new smallest.

Check 87 at index 4: $87 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

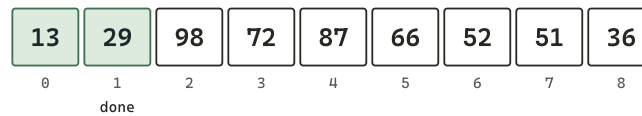
Check 66 at index 5: $66 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

Check 52 at index 6: $52 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

Check 51 at index 7: $51 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

Check 36 at index 8: $36 < 29$ is false. Keep 29 as the smallest.

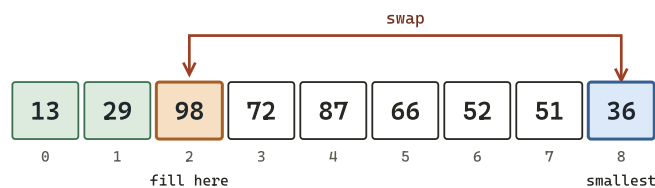
The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value is 29 at index 3. Swap 72 and 29 to fill index 1.



The row is now [13, 29, 98, 72, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]. Position 1 is finished. 72 takes the position that 29 left behind. Next, fill index 2: start with 98 as the smallest and scan from index 3.

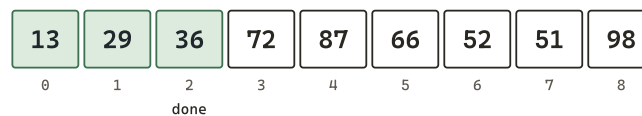
The smallest remaining value is 29 at index 3. Swap 72 and 29 to fill index 1.

Pass 3: fill index 2



Start with [13, 29, 98, 72, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]. Fill index 2; remember 98 at index 2 as the smallest seen so far.
 Check 72 at index 3: $72 < 98$ is true. Remember 72 at index 3 as the new smallest.
 Check 87 at index 4: $87 < 72$ is false. Keep 72 as the smallest.
 Check 66 at index 5: $66 < 72$ is true. Remember 66 at index 5 as the new smallest.
 Check 52 at index 6: $52 < 66$ is true. Remember 52 at index 6 as the new smallest.
 Check 51 at index 7: $51 < 52$ is true. Remember 51 at index 7 as the new smallest.
 Check 36 at index 8: $36 < 51$ is true. Remember 36 at index 8 as the new smallest.

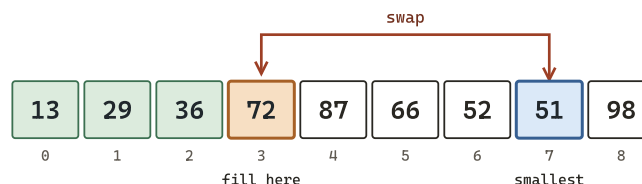
The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value is 36 at index 8. Swap 98 and 36 to fill index 2.



The row is now [13, 29, 36, 72, 87, 66, 52, 51, 98]. Position 2 is finished. 98 takes the position that 36 left behind. Next, fill index 3: start with 72 as the smallest and scan from index 4.

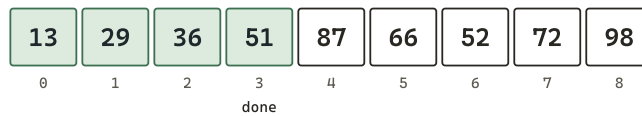
The smallest remaining value is 36 at index 8. Swap 98 and 36 to fill index 2.

Pass 4: fill index 3



Start with [13, 29, 36, 72, 87, 66, 52, 51, 98]. Fill index 3; remember 72 at index 3 as the smallest seen so far.
 Check 87 at index 4: $87 < 72$ is false. Keep 72 as the smallest.
 Check 66 at index 5: $66 < 72$ is true. Remember 66 at index 5 as the new smallest.
 Check 52 at index 6: $52 < 66$ is true. Remember 52 at index 6 as the new smallest.
 Check 51 at index 7: $51 < 52$ is true. Remember 51 at index 7 as the new smallest.
 Check 98 at index 8: $98 < 51$ is false. Keep 51 as the smallest.

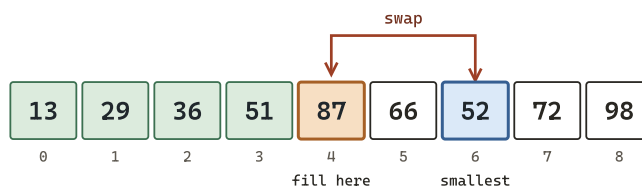
The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value is 51 at index 7. Swap 72 and 51 to fill index 3.



The row is now [13, 29, 36, 51, 87, 66, 52, 72, 98]. Position 3 is finished. 72 takes the position that 51 left behind. Next, fill index 4: start with 87 as the smallest and scan from index 5.

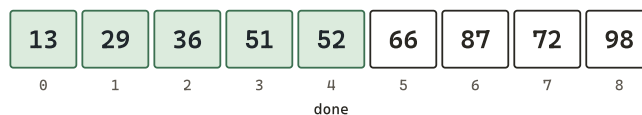
The smallest remaining value is 51 at index 7. Swap 72 and 51 to fill index 3.

Pass 5: fill index 4



Start with [13, 29, 36, 51, 87, 66, 52, 72, 98]. Fill index 4; remember 87 at index 4 as the smallest seen so far. Check 66 at index 5: $66 < 87$ is true. Remember 66 at index 5 as the new smallest. Check 52 at index 6: $52 < 66$ is true. Remember 52 at index 6 as the new smallest. Check 72 at index 7: $72 < 52$ is false. Keep 52 as the smallest. Check 98 at index 8: $98 < 52$ is false. Keep 52 as the smallest.

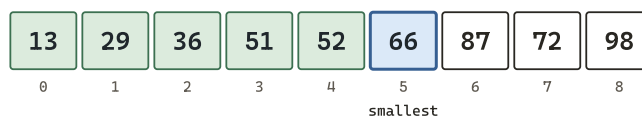
The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value is 52 at index 6. Swap 87 and 52 to fill index 4.



The row is now [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 87, 72, 98]. Position 4 is finished. 87 takes the position that 52 left behind. Next, fill index 5: start with 66 as the smallest and scan from index 6.

The smallest remaining value is 52 at index 6. Swap 87 and 52 to fill index 4.

Pass 6: fill index 5



Start with [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 87, 72, 98]. Fill index 5; remember 66 at index 5 as the smallest seen so far. Check 87 at index 6: $87 < 66$ is false. Keep 66 as the smallest. Check 72 at index 7: $72 < 66$ is false. Keep 66 as the smallest. Check 98 at index 8: $98 < 66$ is false. Keep 66 as the smallest.

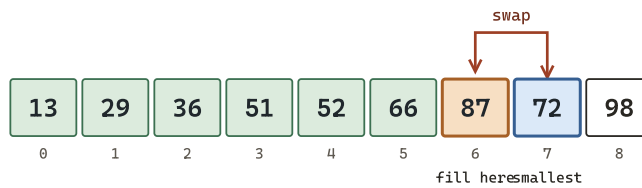
The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value, 66, is already at index 5. Leave it there.



The row is now [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 87, 72, 98]. Position 5 is finished. No swap was needed. Next, fill index 6: start with 87 as the smallest and scan from index 7.

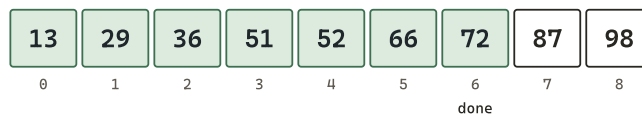
The smallest remaining value, 66, is already at index 5. Leave it there.

Pass 7: fill index 6



Start with [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 87, 72, 98]. Fill index 6; remember 87 at index 6 as the smallest seen so far. Check 72 at index 7: $72 < 87$ is true. Remember 72 at index 7 as the new smallest. Check 98 at index 8: $98 < 72$ is false. Keep 72 as the smallest.

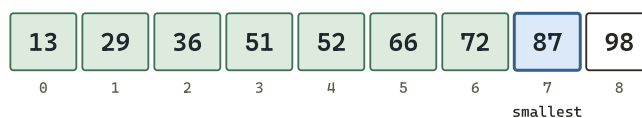
The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value is 72 at index 7. Swap 87 and 72 to fill index 6.



The row is now [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 72, 87, 98]. Position 6 is finished. 87 takes the position that 72 left behind. Next, fill index 7: start with 87 as the smallest and scan from index 8.

The smallest remaining value is 72 at index 7. Swap 87 and 72 to fill index 6.

Pass 8: fill index 7



Start with [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 72, 87, 98]. Fill index 7; remember 87 at index 7 as the smallest seen so far. Check 98 at index 8: $98 < 87$ is false. Keep 87 as the smallest.

The scan is finished. The smallest remaining value, 87, is already at index 7. Leave it there.

13	29	36	51	52	66	72	87	98
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
							done	

The row is now [13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 72, 87, 98]. Position 7 is finished. No swap was needed. Only the last position remains; its value is already in place, so stop.

The smallest remaining value, 87, is already at index 7. Leave it there.

▼ Full trace table - select a row to jump to its scene

PASS	MINIMUM	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER PASS	COMPARISONS
1	13 at 3	0 ↔ 3	[13, 72, 98, 29, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]	8
2	29 at 3	1 ↔ 3	[13, 29, 98, 72, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]	7
3	36 at 8	2 ↔ 8	[13, 29, 36, 72, 87, 66, 52, 51, 98]	6
4	51 at 7	3 ↔ 7	[13, 29, 36, 51, 87, 66, 52, 72, 98]	5
5	52 at 6	4 ↔ 6	[13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 87, 72, 98]	4
6	66 at 5	No swap	[13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 87, 72, 98]	3
7	72 at 7	6 ↔ 7	[13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 72, 87, 98]	2
8	87 at 7	No swap	[13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 72, 87, 98]	1

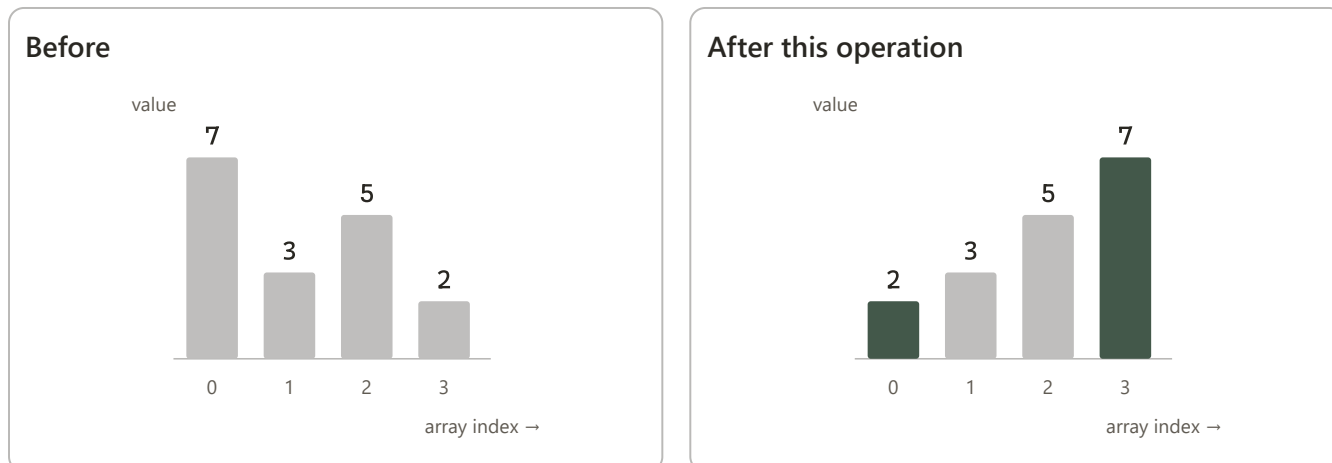
The trace at a glance

PASS	MINIMUM	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER PASS	COMPARISONS
1	13 at 3	0 ↔ 3	[13, 72, 98, 29, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]	8
2	29 at 3	1 ↔ 3	[13, 29, 98, 72, 87, 66, 52, 51, 36]	7
3	36 at 8	2 ↔ 8	[13, 29, 36, 72, 87, 66, 52, 51, 98]	6
4	51 at 7	3 ↔ 7	[13, 29, 36, 51, 87, 66, 52, 72, 98]	5
5	52 at 6	4 ↔ 6	[13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 87, 72, 98]	4
6	66 at 5	No swap	[13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 87, 72, 98]	3
7	72 at 7	6 ↔ 7	[13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 72, 87, 98]	2
8	87 at 7	No swap	[13, 29, 36, 51, 52, 66, 72, 87, 98]	1

Read the algorithm as a bar graph

Bar height means **value**; horizontal position means **index**. All panels below use the same height scale. A taller bar is not “more sorted”.

Find the shortest bar, then exchange two positions



Scan all remaining bars: 2 is the minimum at index 3. After the scan, swap 7 and 2 once. The displaced 7 goes back to index 3. The scan itself changes only `minIndex`; the bars do not move while you search.

Check yourself: identify which indexes are guaranteed final, which values were merely inspected, and whether the operation swapped, shifted or copied data. A sorted ascending array has non-decreasing heights, including equal-height neighbours.

Fully annotated Java: connect each line to the movement

java

```
public static void selectionSort(int[] arr) {
    // Fill each final position from left to right.
    for (int i = 0; i < arr.length - 1; i++) {
        int min = i; // Store an INDEX, not a value.
        // Scan the complete unsorted suffix before swapping anything.
        for (int j = i + 1; j < arr.length; j++) {
            if (arr[j] < arr[min]) min = j;
        }
        // At most one swap per pass; skip a redundant self-swap.
        if (min != i) {
            int temp = arr[i]; arr[i] = arr[min]; arr[min] = temp;
        }
    }
}
```

Write it from scratch

- Choose the next final position.
- Initialize the minimum index to it.

- Scan the complete suffix.
 - Remember better candidate indexes.
 - Perform at most one final swap.
-

Topic quiz: try it yourself

Answer all 12 questions. Choose an option to see the reasoning; reset to retry. The printable answer key follows the questions.

1. What is the last valid index of an array of length 6?

- ☐ A. 5
- ☐ B. 6
- ☐ C. 7

2. What does $O(1)$ auxiliary space describe?

- ☐ A. Exactly one machine instruction
- ☐ B. The input contains one value
- ☐ C. Extra storage stays bounded as n grows

3. What is a loop invariant?

- ☐ A. A loop that never terminates
- ☐ B. A statement that remains true at a specified loop boundary
- ☐ C. A variable that never changes

4. What does stable sorting preserve?

- ☐ A. The original relative order of records with equal keys
- ☐ B. Every original array index
- ☐ C. The original order of unequal keys

5. What should a correct ascending sort do with [] and [7]?

- ☐ A. Throw an error for both
- ☐ B. Add a zero to each
- ☐ C. Leave both unchanged

6. When does ordinary selection sort swap?

- ☐ A. Before looking at the suffix
- ☐ B. After the complete suffix scan
- ☐ C. Every time a new minimum is seen

7. What does min store?

- ☐ A. The index of the best candidate
- ☐ B. The minimum value itself
- ☐ C. The number of swaps

8. Opening map: the first selected minimum and destination?

- ☐ A. 29 goes to index 8
- ☐ B. 36 goes to index 0
- ☐ C. 13 goes to index 0

9. What happens on the opening map's sixth pass?

- ☐ A. The algorithm stops scanning permanently
- ☐ B. 66 is already in position; no swap
- ☐ C. 66 swaps with 98

10. Comparisons on a sorted five-value input?

☐ A. 10

☐ B. 4

☐ C. 0

11. Maximum actual swaps for n values when self-swaps are skipped?

☐ A. $n(n - 1)/2$

☐ B. Always zero

☐ C. $n - 1$

12. What does sorting [2a, 2b, 1] demonstrate?

☐ A. Duplicates prevent termination

☐ B. Long swaps can reverse equal-key order

☐ C. Selection sort is stable

▼ Answer key and explanations

1. **5.** Indexes start at 0, so the last index is $\text{length} - 1$.
2. **Extra storage stays bounded as n grows.** Auxiliary space counts extra working storage, excluding the input array.
3. **A statement that remains true at a specified loop boundary.** The invariant explains why each iteration preserves progress toward a correct result.
4. **The original relative order of records with equal keys.** Tags such as 2a and 2b let you check whether equal-key records crossed.
5. **Leave both unchanged.** Both inputs are already sorted; no key comparison is necessary.
6. **After the complete suffix scan.** The scan remembers an index; the final minimum is moved only after scanning.
7. **The index of the best candidate.** `arr[min]` accesses the candidate value, whereas `min` identifies its position.
8. **13 goes to index 0.** 13 is the smallest of all nine values. It swaps with 29.
9. **66 is already in position; no swap.** A no-swap pass fixes one position; it does not prove the entire remaining suffix sorted.
10. **10.** Selection sort still scans suffixes of lengths 4, 3, 2, 1.
11. **$n - 1$.** There is at most one exchange per outer pass.
12. **Long swaps can reverse equal-key order.** The first swap yields [1, 2b, 2a], so this ordinary version is unstable.

The textbook definition

Sorting / Selection sort · The textbook definition

The textbook definition

Selection sort is a comparison-based sorting algorithm that divides the array into a sorted prefix on the left and an unsorted suffix on the right. In each iteration it *scans the whole unsorted suffix* to find the smallest

value, then swaps that value into the first position of the suffix. The sorted prefix therefore grows by one cell per iteration, and every cell in it is already in its final place.

Sorted prefix

The cells $0 \dots i - 1$. They hold the smallest values, in order, and never change again.

Unsorted suffix

The cells $i \dots n - 1$. The next minimum is somewhere in here.

Boundary i

The first cell of the unsorted suffix, which is the cell about to be filled.

Scan

Looking at every cell of the suffix once, comparing it with the best candidate so far.

`minIndex`

The *position* of the smallest value found so far. We remember where it is, not just what it is.

Swap

Exchanging `array[i]` with `array[minIndex]`. There is at most one per iteration.

The name says what it does: each iteration **selects** the right value for the next position, rather than shuffling values into place as bubble and insertion sort do.

In plain language

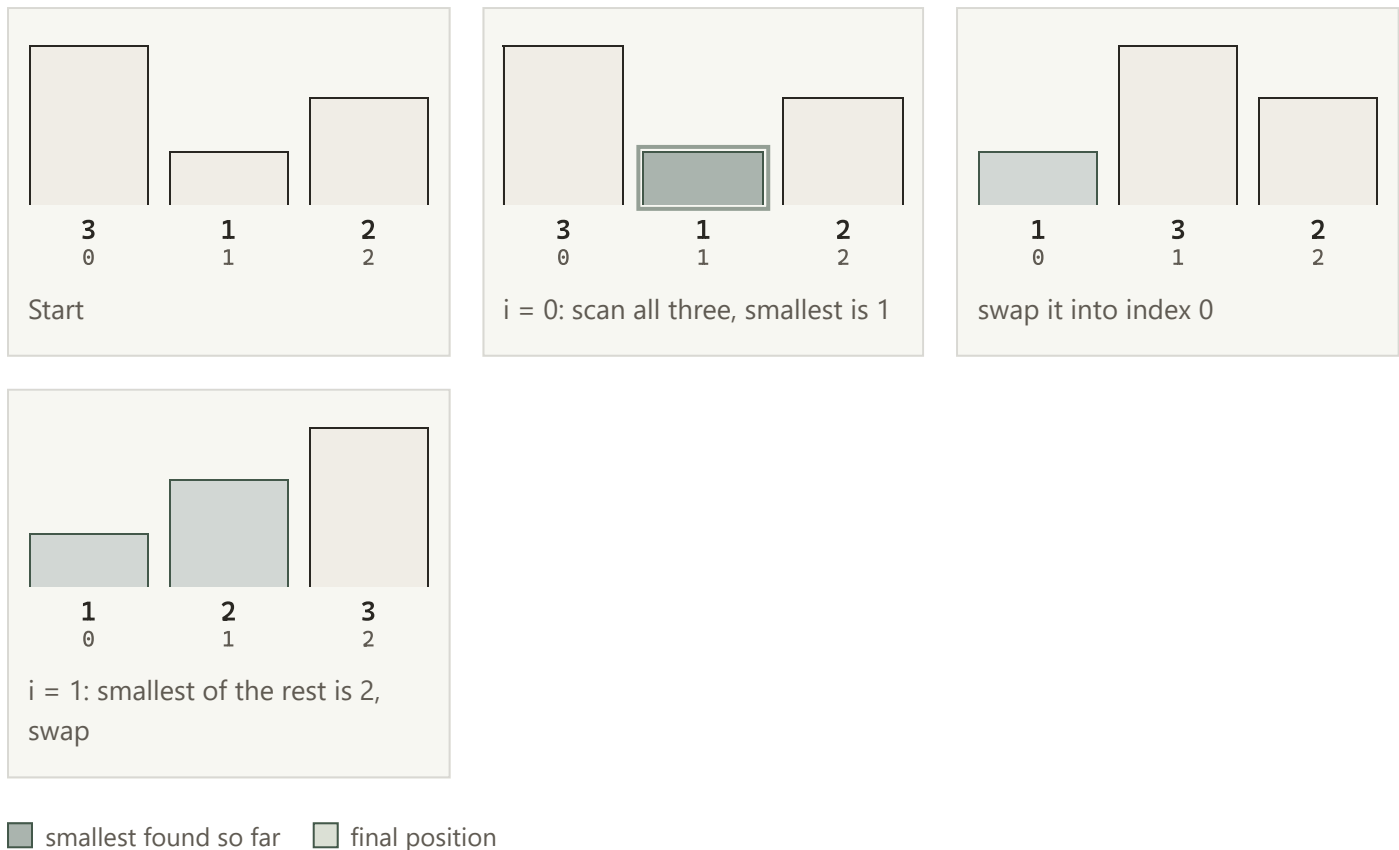
Sorting / Selection sort · In plain language

In plain language

Keep choosing the smallest card from the pile that is left, and lay it down next in the row.

Imagine a pile of numbered cards on a table. Look through **all** of them and pull out the smallest; put it at the left end of your row. Now look through the cards that are left, pull out the smallest of those, and put it next in the row. Keep going until the pile is empty. Your row is sorted.

In an array there is no separate table: the “pile” is the part of the array to the right of the boundary, and “putting it in the row” means swapping the chosen value into the boundary cell. Whatever was sitting in that cell goes to the place the chosen value came from.



Two iterations were enough for three values: the last cell is automatically correct when all the others are, so the loop only runs $n - 1$ times.

The main idea

Sorting / Selection sort · The main idea

The main idea

Selection sort splits the array in two with a movable boundary. Everything left of the boundary is **finished**; everything right of it is untouched. The whole algorithm is: *find the smallest value on the right, put it at the boundary, move the boundary one cell right.*

One scan for the minimum

Here is the scan for $i = 0$. We start by assuming index 0 holds the minimum, then look at every other cell. Whenever we meet something smaller we move our “minimum so far” marker to it. Only when the scan ends do we know the true minimum and swap once.



The prefix is final, not just sorted

This is the biggest difference from insertion sort. In insertion sort the left part is sorted *among itself* but later values may still be inserted in the middle. In selection sort the left part holds the globally smallest values, so a finished cell is **never touched again**.

After $i = 0$ · swapped index 0 with index 3



After $i = 1$ · the minimum was already in place, so nothing moved



After $i = 2$ · swapped index 2 with index 4



After $i = 3$ · the minimum was already in place, so nothing moved



The cost of choosing

Finding the minimum means looking at every cell of the suffix, every time, even if the array was sorted to begin with. The algorithm has no way to know the minimum is already in place until it has checked. That is what you pay for the very small number of swaps.

The repeating recipe: set `minIndex = i` → scan `i + 1 .. n - 1`, updating `minIndex` whenever a smaller value appears → swap `array[i]` with `array[minIndex]` → move `i` right.

Scan, select, swap

Sorting / Selection sort · Scan, select, swap

Scan, select, swap

Selection sort separates *finding* from *moving*. Seeing them as two phases makes the code and the trace easy to follow.

Comparison

A question inside the scan: `array[j] < array[minIndex]`. Every iteration makes $n - 1 - i$ of them, regardless of the data.

Selection

Deciding which cell holds the minimum. Nothing in the array moves during this phase.

Swap

The only movement: one exchange per iteration at most, and none if the minimum is already at `i`.

Iteration

One value of `i`: a full scan plus (maybe) one swap.

Why remember the index, not the value?

Knowing that the smallest value is 1 is not enough: to swap we must know *where* the 1 is. That is why the code keeps `minIndex`. A common slip is to store `min = array[j]` and then be unable to find its position.

One swap can move a value a long way

Bubble sort moves values one neighbour at a time. Selection sort's swap jumps: in iteration 0 the 4 and the 1 trade places across three cells. That long jump is what keeps the swap count tiny, but it also has a price, which you will meet in the section on stability: jumping over equal values can reorder them.

STEP	CODE	EFFECT ON [4, 2, 5, 1, 3]
scan	<pre>for (j = i + 1; j < n; j++) if (a[j] < a[minIndex]) minIndex = j;</pre>	minIndex ends at 3 (the value 1). Nothing has moved yet.
swap	<pre>temp = a[i]; a[i] = a[minIndex]; a[minIndex] = temp;</pre>	[1, 2, 5, 4, 3]: the 4 and the 1 trade places.

Counting rule: **comparisons** for this array total 10 no matter what; **swaps** total 2. Compare that with bubble sort's 6 swaps on the same array.

Select the smallest remaining value

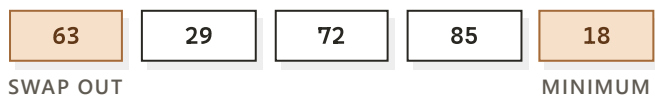
Sorting / Selection sort

Select the smallest remaining value

Selection sort scans the unsorted section for its smallest value, then swaps that value into the next open position. The sorted section grows from left to right.

Illustration · choose the first minimum

In [63, 29, 72, 85, 18], begin with 63 as the assumed minimum. Comparing the remaining values eventually finds 18 at index 4.



Swap 63 and 18:



Trace table

POSITION	MINIMUM FOUND	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER PLACEMENT	COMPARISONS
0	18 at index 4	Swap 63 ↔ 18	[18, 29, 72, 85, 63]	4

POSITION	MINIMUM FOUND	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER PLACEMENT	COMPARISONS
1	29 at index 1	No swap needed	[18,29,72,85,63]	3
2	63 at index 4	Swap 72 ↔ 63	[18,29,63,85,72]	2
3	72 at index 4	Swap 85 ↔ 72	[18,29,63,72,85]	1

Implementation

Selection sort

```
public static void selectionSort(int[] arr) {
    // i is the next position to fill in the sorted prefix.
    for (int i = 0; i < arr.length - 1; i++) {
        int minIndex = i;
        // Search the unsorted suffix for its smallest value.
        for (int j = i + 1; j < arr.length; j++) {
            if (arr[j] < arr[minIndex]) minIndex = j;
        }
        // Place the selected minimum at i; avoid a self-swap.
        if (minIndex != i) {
            int temp = arr[i];
            arr[i] = arr[minIndex];
            arr[minIndex] = temp;
        }
    }
}
```

▼ Recursive selection sort

First call: `selectionSortRec(arr, 0)`.

```

public static void selectionSortRec(int[] arr, int start) {
    // Base case: fewer than two values remain.
    if (start ≥ arr.length - 1) return;

    int minIndex = start;
    // Find the minimum in start..last.
    for (int j = start + 1; j < arr.length; j++) {
        if (arr[j] < arr[minIndex]) minIndex = j;
    }
    if (minIndex ≠ start) {
        int temp = arr[start];
        arr[start] = arr[minIndex];
        arr[minIndex] = temp;
    }
    // The prefix gained one fixed value; solve the suffix.
    selectionSortRec(arr, start + 1);
}

```

Write it from scratch

- 1 Choose the next position **i**.
- 2 Assume **i** holds the minimum.
- 3 Scan the suffix and update **minIndex**.
- 4 Swap the minimum into **i**.

Ascending ↔ descending

For ascending, select the minimum with **<**. For descending, select the maximum with **>**.

Same array, opposite choice: on [63, 29, 72, 85, 18] with **i** = 0, ascending selects 18 (index 4) and descending selects 85 (index 3).

Debug checklist

- Store an index, not only the minimum value.
- Start the inner loop at **i + 1**.
- Swap only after the scan finishes.

Worked example · full run on [4, 2, 5, 1, 3]

The orange divider marks the end of the sorted prefix. Dashed-outline cells mark the position **i** being filled; the raised cell is the minimum found.

i = 0 · fill index 0 with the smallest of the remaining values



Scan indexes 1–4 (4 comparisons). The smallest remaining value is 1 at index 3. Swap index 0 (4) with index 3 (1).



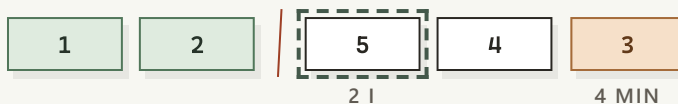
i = 1 · fill index 1 with the smallest of the remaining values



Scan indexes 2–4 (3 comparisons). The smallest remaining value is 2 at index 1. Index 1 already holds the minimum, so no swap is needed.



i = 2 · fill index 2 with the smallest of the remaining values



Scan indexes 3–4 (2 comparisons). The smallest remaining value is 3 at index 4. Swap index 2 (5) with index 4 (3).



i = 3 · fill index 3 with the smallest of the remaining values



Scan index 4 (1 comparison). The smallest remaining value is 4 at index 3. Index 3 already holds the minimum, so no swap is needed.



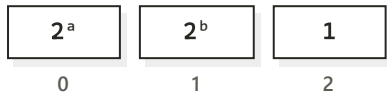
I	MINIMUM FOUND	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER	COMPARISONS
0	1 at index 3	Swap	[1, 2, 5, 4, 3]	4
1	2 at index 1	No swap	[1, 2, 5, 4, 3]	3
2	3 at index 4	Swap	[1, 2, 3, 4, 5]	2
3	4 at index 3	No swap	[1, 2, 3, 4, 5]	1
Total	—	2 swaps	Sorted	10

Sorted: 10 comparisons but only 2 swaps, compared with 6 swaps for bubble sort on the same array.

Why selection sort is not stable

The swap moves a value across everything between the two positions, which can jump it over an equal value. Label two equal 2s as 2^a and 2^b and sort $[2^a, 2^b, 1]$: the minimum 1 is swapped with 2^a .

Before



After the swap at $i = 0$



2^b now sits before 2^a , so the equal values changed relative order. Insertion sort avoids this because it never moves a value past an equal one. Merge sort avoids it because, on a tie, the merge takes the left value first ($\leq$).

Best case · already sorted

For $[1, 2, 3, 4]$, each scan confirms that the first unsorted value is already the minimum.

The sorted boundary grows, but the scans do not disappear

1

2

3

4

$i = 0 \cdot 3 \text{ CHECKS} \cdot 2 \text{ CHECKS} \cdot 1 \text{ CHECK} \quad \text{FINAL}$

Comparisons: $3 + 2 + 1 = 6$ · swaps: 0 · still $O(n^2)$.

I	SUFFIX SCANNED	MININDEX	COMPARISONS	SWAP?
0	[1, 2, 3, 4]	0	3	No
1	[2, 3, 4]	1	2	No

I	SUFFIX SCANNED	MININDEX	COMPARISONS	SWAP?
2	[3,4]	2	1	No

BEST $O(n^2)$	AVERAGE $O(n^2)$
WORST $O(n^2)$	STABLE No
IN-PLACE Yes	ADAPTIVE No
ITERATIVE SPACE $O(1)$	RECURSIVE SPACE $O(n)$

Questions

▼ Why might selection sort be chosen over bubble sort?

Selection sort makes at most one swap per outer iteration, so it can be useful when writes or swaps are expensive.

▼ Why is it not adaptive?

It scans the entire remaining unsorted section to find the minimum even when the array is already sorted.

Selection sort in one sentence

Find the smallest value in the unsorted suffix and swap it into the next position of the sorted prefix.

Recursion, calls and returns

● ● ● java

```
public static void selectionSortRec(int[] arr, int i) {
    // Zero or one position remains to fill.
    if (i ≥ arr.length - 1) return;
    int min = i;
    for (int j = i + 1; j < arr.length; j++) {
        if (arr[j] < arr[min]) min = j;
    }
    if (min ≠ i) {
        int temp = arr[i]; arr[i] = arr[min]; arr[min] = temp;
    }
    // The completed prefix grows; the remaining suffix shrinks.
    selectionSortRec(arr, i + 1);
    // First call: selectionSortRec(arr, 0).
}
```

CALL STACK - NEWEST FRAME AT THE TOP

selectionSortRec(i=1)

Scan suffix 1..4 and fill index 1

selectionSortRec(i=0)

Waiting: Child fills remaining positions 1..4

Unlike iterative auxiliary space, suspended recursive frames require $O(n)$ stack space in the worst case.

A complete runnable Java example

Save as `SelectionDemo.java`. The code includes the method(s) and a main entry point.

```
import java.util.Arrays;

public class SelectionDemo {
    public static void selectionSort(int[] arr) {
        // Fill each final position from left to right.
        for (int i = 0; i < arr.length - 1; i++) {
            int min = i; // Store an INDEX, not a value.
            // Scan the complete unsorted suffix before swapping anything.
            for (int j = i + 1; j < arr.length; j++) {
                if (arr[j] < arr[min]) min = j;
            }
            // At most one swap per pass; skip a redundant self-swap.
            if (min != i) {
                int temp = arr[i]; arr[i] = arr[min]; arr[min] = temp;
            }
        }
    }

    public static void main(String[] args) {
        int[] values = {4, 2, 5, 1, 3};
        selectionSort(values);
        System.out.println(Arrays.toString(values));
    }
}
```

```
[1, 2, 3, 4, 5]
```

Properties

Sorting / Selection sort · Properties

Properties

BEST TIME $O(n^2)$	AVERAGE TIME $O(n^2)$
WORST TIME $O(n^2)$	EXTRA SPACE $O(1)$
STABLE No	IN-PLACE Yes
ADAPTIVE No	SWAPS $\leq n - 1$

Not stable

The long-distance swap can jump a value over an equal one. In $[2^a, 2^b, 1]$ the first swap moves 2^a behind 2^b , and nothing later repairs it. A stable version exists (shift instead of swap), but that is a different algorithm.

In-place

Only the array and a few variables are used: $O(1)$ extra space.

Not adaptive

The scan always examines the whole suffix, so sorted input costs exactly the same $n(n - 1) / 2$ comparisons as random input.

Fewest swaps

At most one swap per iteration, so at most $n - 1$ swaps in total, the smallest of the simple sorts. Bubble sort can need up to $n(n - 1) / 2$.

Comparison-based

Every decision comes from comparing two values.

Why those complexities occur

Sorting / Selection sort · Why those complexities occur

Why those complexities occur

Every case · $O(n^2)$ comparisons

The scan for iteration i always looks at $n - 1 - i$ cells, whatever the values are.

Swaps · at most $n - 1$

One per iteration, so the writing is only $O(n)$: that is selection sort's one real advantage.

The comparison staircase never changes

$i = 1$		4
$i = 2$		3
$i = 3$		2
$i = 4$		1

total = $4 + 3 + 2 + 1 = 10$

The staircase is exactly the same one bubble sort walks in its worst case, and for the same reason it totals $n(n - 1) / 2$. The difference is that for selection sort this is the cost *every time*: there is no best case that avoids it.

$$(n - 1) + (n - 2) + \dots + 1 = n(n - 1) / 2 \rightarrow O(n^2)$$

comparisons, always

N (VALUES)	COMPARISONS	MAXIMUM SWAPS
5	10	4
10	45	9
100	4,950	99
1,000	499,500	999

Read across the row for 1,000 values: nearly half a million comparisons but never more than 999 swaps. If a swap were expensive (large records, slow storage) that gap would matter; if comparisons are the cost, selection sort has no way to save any.

Space

Only i , j , minIndex and temp : $O(1)$.

When to use it

Sorting / Selection sort · When to use it

When to use it

A good choice

Small arrays; situations where

writing

is much more expensive than reading (flash memory, very large records, writing to a file); when you need a predictable, data-independent running time; and when simplicity matters more than speed.

A poor choice

Large arrays ($O(n^2)$ comparisons); data that is already or nearly sorted (it cannot take advantage); anywhere stability is needed, for example sorting records by one field while keeping an earlier order for ties.

Compared with its relatives: **insertion sort** beats it on nearly sorted data and is stable; **bubble sort** makes many more swaps; **merge sort** is far faster on large arrays. Selection sort is a good answer to “which simple sort minimises swaps?”, and almost nothing else.

Why sort data at all?

Sorting · Why sort data at all?

Why sort data at all?

Before the algorithms: what does sorted data give you that unsorted data does not, and what does it cost?

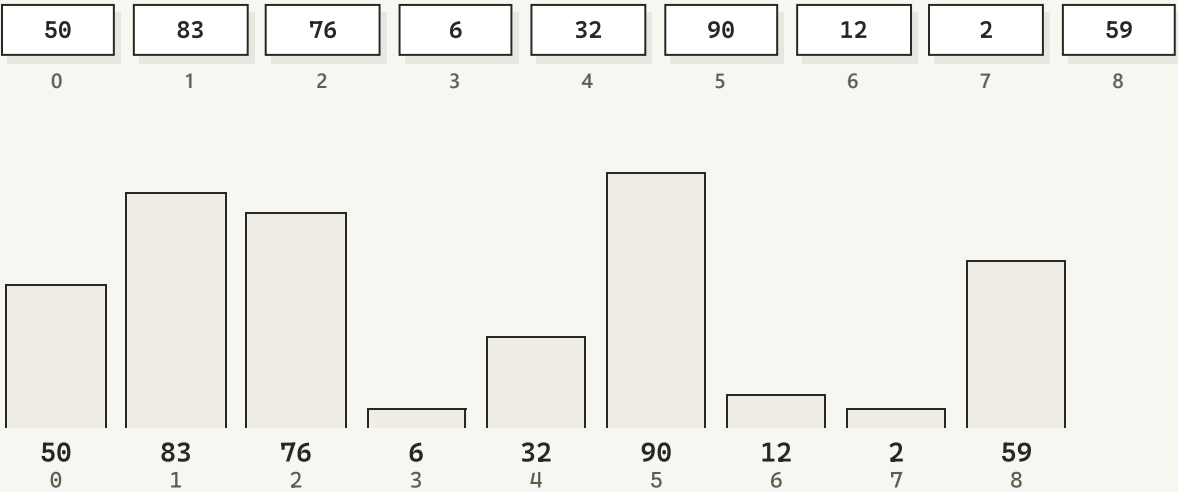
Everything in this chapter is about putting values in order. Before learning *how*, it is worth being clear about **why**, because it is a favourite exam question and because it explains why searching and sorting are taught together.

Short answer for a test: sorting data makes it easier and faster to find information in it. A sorted array can be searched with binary search, in $O(\log n)$ instead of $O(n)$.

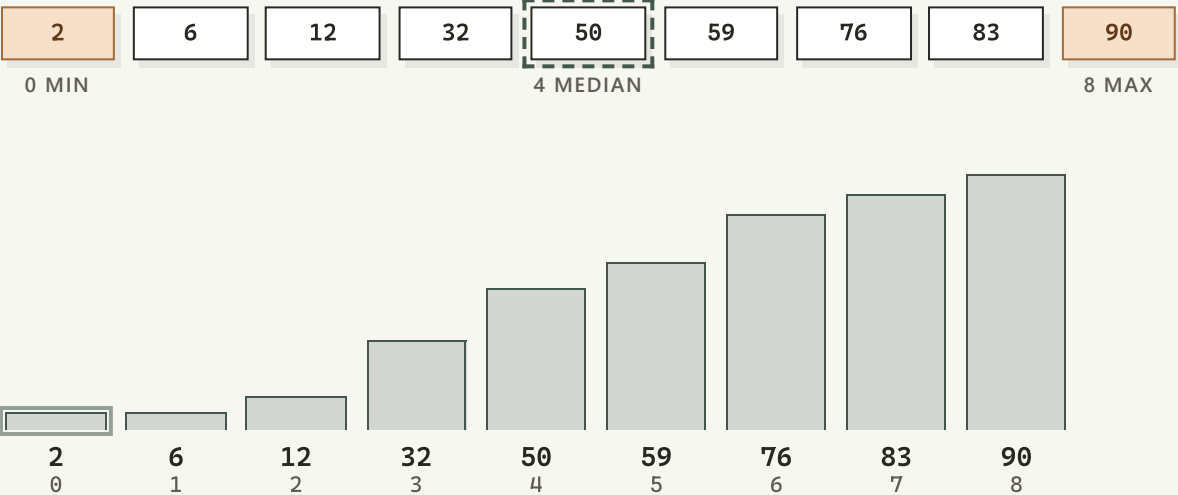
What becomes easy once data is sorted

Take the nine values from the past paper. Unsorted they tell you nothing at a glance; sorted, a lot of questions answer themselves.

UNSORTED



THE SAME VALUES, SORTED ASCENDING



QUESTION	UNSORTED ARRAY	SORTED ARRAY
Smallest and largest value?	Look at all 9 cells	The first and last cell: 2 and 90
Median (middle) value?	Needs a lot of work	The middle cell: 50
Is a value present?	Linear search: up to 9 comparisons	Binary search: at most 4 probes
Where are the duplicates?	Anywhere	Next to each other (see below)
Merge two lists?	No shortcut	Merge them by zipping (that is merge sort's merge step)
Show a list to a person?	Hard to read	Alphabetical or numerical order, easy to scan

Duplicates end up side by side

Finding repeated values in [3, 1, 3, 2, 3] means comparing every pair. After sorting, [1, 2, 3, 3, 3], equal values are neighbours, so one pass comparing each cell with the next finds them all.

Sorting is not free: is it worth it?

Sorting costs about $n \log_2 n$ steps, and it only pays off if you search more than a few times. Suppose you have **1,000,000** values and will search for **1,000** different keys:

STRATEGY	WORK	TOTAL
Never sort: linear search every time	1,000 searches × up to 1,000,000 comparisons	1,000,000,000
Sort once, then binary search every time	sort ≈ 20,000,000 steps, then 1,000 searches × 20 probes	20,020,000

That is about **49× less work** after sorting. With a single search the answer flips: scanning once costs 1,000,000 and sorting first costs 20,000,000. The rule: *search once, scan; search often, sort first*.

▼ Quick check: Exam-style question 3(a), “What is the purpose of sorting data?”

To arrange data in a defined order (ascending or descending) so that information is easier and faster to find, for example by using binary search instead of scanning every element. Other valid points: duplicates become adjacent, minimum and maximum are at the ends, and sorted data is easier to read and merge.

The sorting map

Sorting

The sorting map

Every algorithm orders values, but each uses a different repeated action. The four are taught in this order: Bubble, Selection, Insertion, Merge.

ALGORITHM	REPEATED ACTION	TYPICAL TIME	BEST FIT
Bubble	Compare neighbours; swap wrong pairs	$O(n^2)$	Learning and tiny inputs
Selection	Find the smallest remaining value; place it next	$O(n^2)$	When few swaps matter
Insertion	Shift larger sorted values; insert a key	$O(n^2)$	Small or nearly sorted data

ALGORITHM	REPEATED ACTION	TYPICAL TIME	BEST FIT
Merge	Divide into halves; merge sorted halves	$O(n \log n)$	Large data and predictable speed

Vocabulary behind every property tile

Comparison-based Order is decided only by asking questions such as $a < b$.	Best / average / worst The same algorithm on three arrangements of the same n values: already ordered, typical, and the most awkward.
In-place Values are rearranged inside the original array using only a few extra variables: $O(1)$ auxiliary space.	Auxiliary space Extra memory beyond the input array, such as the temporary copies merge sort makes.
Adaptive Does less work when the input is already or nearly sorted.	Stable Equal values keep their original relative order.

Why stability matters

Sort these students by mark. Ana and Ben both scored 70, and Ana was listed first.

Start

70	70	65
ANA	BEN	CY

Stable sort result

65	70	70
CY	ANA	BEN

An unstable sort may give

65	70	70
CY	BEN	ANA

Both outputs are sorted by mark. Only the stable one keeps Ana before Ben, which matters when you sort by one field and want an earlier ordering by another field preserved.

Count the disorder: inversions

An **inversion** is a pair of positions whose values are in the wrong order: a larger value sits to the left of a smaller one. $[4, 2, 5, 1, 3]$ has six: $(4,2), (4,1), (4,3), (2,1), (5,1), (5,3)$.

ALGORITHM	WHAT IS COUNTED	ON [4, 2, 5, 1, 3]	LINK TO INVERSIONS
Bubble	adjacent swaps	6	Each swap of neighbours removes exactly one inversion.
Insertion	shifts	6	Each shift removes exactly one inversion.
Selection	swaps	2	At most $n - 1$ swaps; one swap can remove several inversions at once.

A fully reversed array of n values has $n(n - 1) / 2$ inversions. For [5, 4, 3, 2, 1] that is 10, which equals the 10 shifts in the reverse-order insertion example. This is the reason bubble and insertion sort are $O(n^2)$ in the worst case.

Descending order

Sorting / Selection sort · Descending order

Descending order

To sort largest to smallest, select the **largest** value of the suffix instead of the smallest. Only the comparison changes, and the variable is best renamed so the code still reads honestly.

Ascending: pick the minimum

```

if (arr[j] < arr[minIndex]) {
    minIndex = j;
}

```

Descending: pick the maximum

```

if (arr[j] > arr[maxIndex]) {
    maxIndex = j;
}

```

ITERATION	ASCENDING (CHOOSSES THE SMALLEST)	DESCENDING (CHOOSSES THE LARGEST)
i = 0	[1, 2, 5, 4, 3] · swap	[5, 2, 4, 1, 3] · swap
i = 1	[1, 2, 5, 4, 3] · no swap	[5, 4, 2, 1, 3] · swap
i = 2	[1, 2, 3, 4, 5] · swap	[5, 4, 3, 1, 2] · swap
i = 3	[1, 2, 3, 4, 5] · no swap	[5, 4, 3, 2, 1] · swap

Ascending made **2 swaps**, descending **4**, and both made the same **10 comparisons**. The comparison count never depends on direction or on the data, only the number of swaps does.

Worked examples

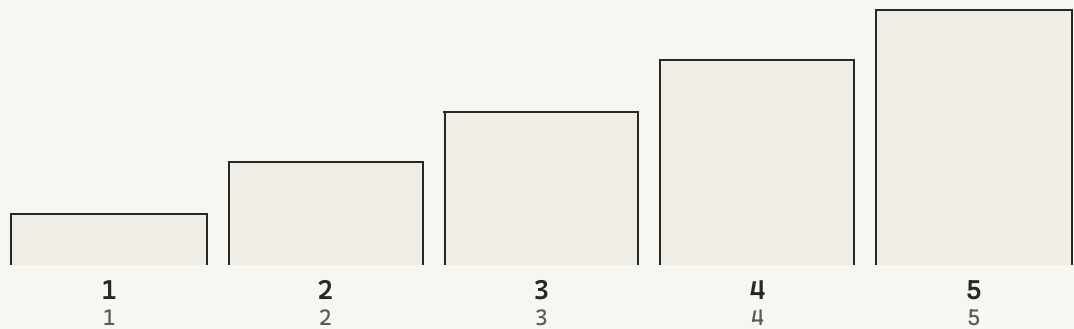
Sorting / Selection sort · Worked examples

Worked examples

Five arrays: no disorder, a reversed array, the most swaps, duplicates and a longer run.

Already sorted · [1, 2, 3, 4, 5]

Every minimum is already sitting at the boundary.



Start: nothing is sorted



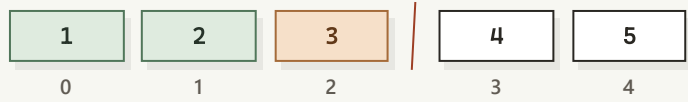
After i = 0 · cells 0..0 are final



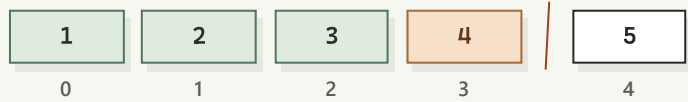
After i = 1 · cells 0..1 are final



After $i = 2$ · cells 0..2 are final



After $i = 3$ · cells 0..3 are final

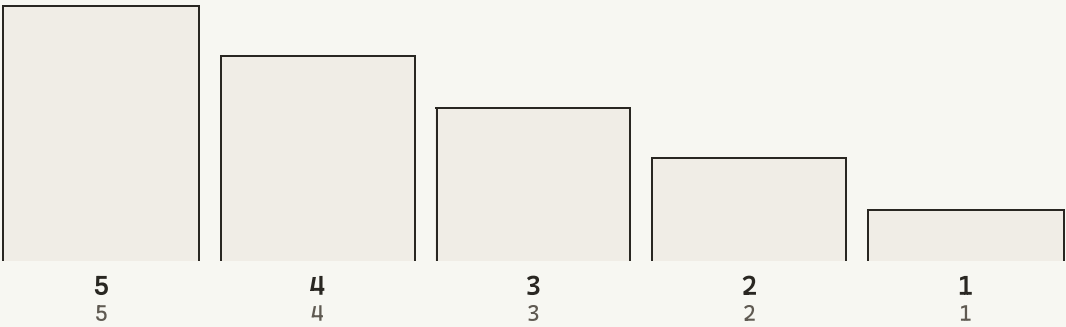


I	CHOICE	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER THE ITERATION	COMPARISONS
Start	—	—	[1, 2, 3, 4, 5]	—
0	smallest of the unsorted part is 1 at index 0	already in place: no swap	[1, 2, 3, 4, 5]	4
1	smallest of the unsorted part is 2 at index 1	already in place: no swap	[1, 2, 3, 4, 5]	3
2	smallest of the unsorted part is 3 at index 2	already in place: no swap	[1, 2, 3, 4, 5]	2
3	smallest of the unsorted part is 4 at index 3	already in place: no swap	[1, 2, 3, 4, 5]	1
Total		0 swaps	sorted	10

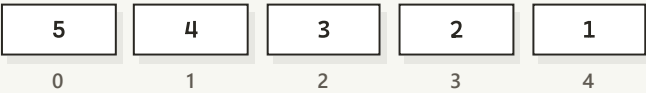
10 comparisons and 0 swaps. The data is perfectly sorted and selection sort still makes all 10 comparisons: it cannot know the answer without looking. That is why it is not adaptive.

Reverse order · [5, 4, 3, 2, 1]

A surprise: the worst-looking input is not the worst case for swaps.



Start: nothing is sorted



After i = 0 · cells 0..0 are final



After i = 1 · cells 0..1 are final



After i = 2 · cells 0..2 are final



After i = 3 · cells 0..3 are final



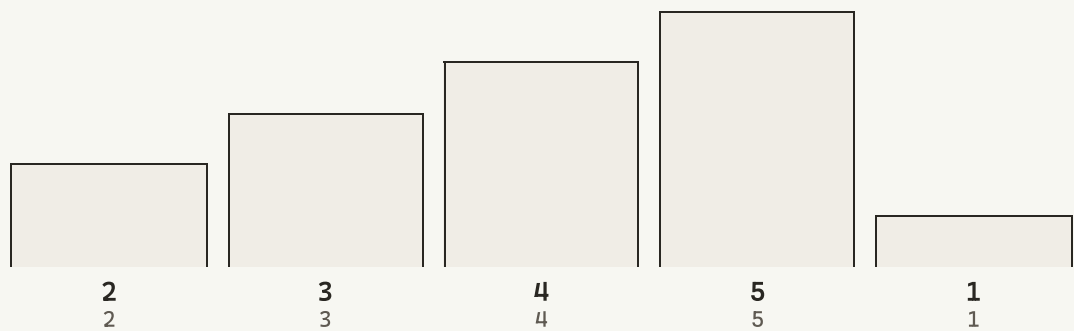
I	CHOICE	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER THE ITERATION	COMPARISONS
Start	—	—	[5, 4, 3, 2, 1]	—

I	CHOICE	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER THE ITERATION	COMPARISONS
0	smallest of the unsorted part is 1 at index 4	swap index 0 with index 4	[1, 4, 3, 2, 5]	4
1	smallest of the unsorted part is 2 at index 3	swap index 1 with index 3	[1, 2, 3, 4, 5]	3
2	smallest of the unsorted part is 3 at index 2	already in place: no swap	[1, 2, 3, 4, 5]	2
3	smallest of the unsorted part is 4 at index 3	already in place: no swap	[1, 2, 3, 4, 5]	1
Total		2 swaps	sorted	10

10 comparisons but only 2 swaps. Each swap sends one value to each end at the same time, and the middle value needs nothing, so a reversed array needs about $n / 2$ swaps.

The most swaps · [2, 3, 4, 5, 1]

The minimum is at the far end, then the next minimum is at the far end of what remains, and so on.



Start: nothing is sorted



After i = 0 · cells 0..0 are final



After i = 1 · cells 0..1 are final



After i = 2 · cells 0..2 are final



After i = 3 · cells 0..3 are final

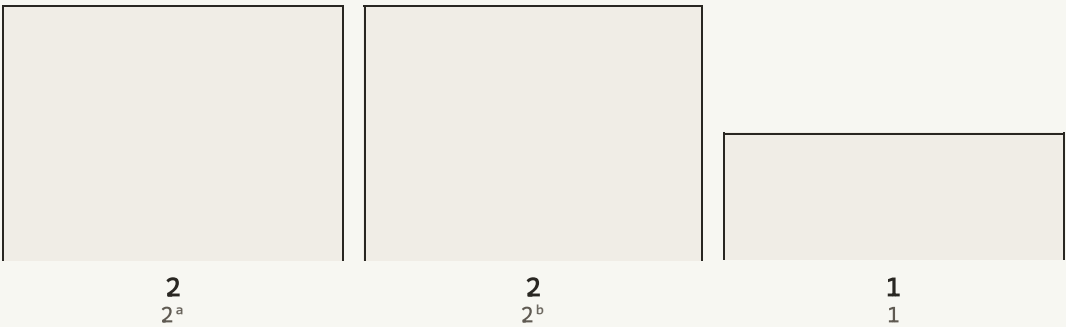


I	CHOICE	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER THE ITERATION	COMPARISONS
Start	—	—	[2, 3, 4, 5, 1]	—
0	smallest of the unsorted part is 1 at index 4	swap index 0 with index 4	[1, 3, 4, 5, 2]	4
1	smallest of the unsorted part is 2 at index 4	swap index 1 with index 4	[1, 2, 4, 5, 3]	3
2	smallest of the unsorted part is 3 at index 4	swap index 2 with index 4	[1, 2, 3, 5, 4]	2
3	smallest of the unsorted part is 4 at index 4	swap index 3 with index 4	[1, 2, 3, 4, 5]	1
Total		4 swaps	sorted	10

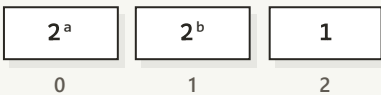
10 comparisons and 4 swaps, which is the maximum $n - 1$. Even this worst case for swaps is tiny next to the 10 comparisons.

Duplicates · $[2^a, 2^b, 1]$

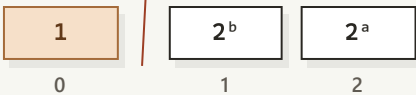
Two equal values, labelled so we can follow them.



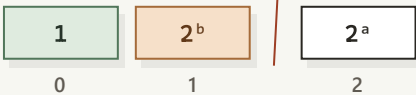
Start: nothing is sorted



After $i = 0$ · cells $0..0$ are final



After $i = 1$ · cells $0..1$ are final



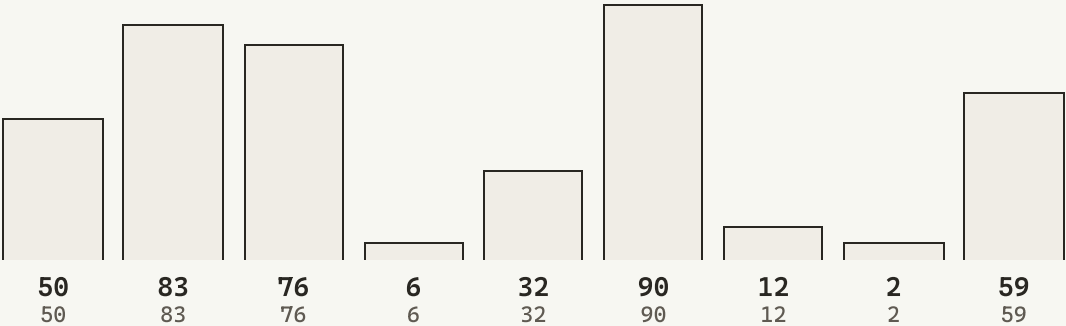
I	CHOICE	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER THE ITERATION	COMPARISONS
Start	—	—	$[2^a, 2^b, 1]$	—
0	smallest of the unsorted part is 1 at index 2	swap index 0 with index 2	$[1, 2^b, 2^a]$	2

I	CHOICE	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER THE ITERATION	COMPARISONS
1	smallest of the unsorted part is 2 ^b at index 1	already in place: no swap	[1, 2 ^b , 2 ^a]	1
Total		1 swaps	sorted	3

The result is [1, 2^b, 2^a]: the two 2s came out in the *opposite* order. The first swap threw 2^a to the far end, past 2^b. So selection sort is **not stable**.

A longer array · [50, 83, 76, 6, 32, 90, 12, 2, 59] (nine values)

The array from the past paper, question 3. The table shows every iteration; try to predict the minimum before reading each row.



I	CHOICE	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER THE ITERATION	COMPARISONS
Start	—	—	[50, 83, 76, 6, 32, 90, 12, 2, 59]	—
0	smallest of the unsorted part is 2 at index 7	swap index 0 with index 7	[2, 83, 76, 6, 32, 90, 12, 50, 59]	8
1	smallest of the unsorted part is 6 at index 3	swap index 1 with index 3	[2, 6, 76, 83, 32, 90, 12, 50, 59]	7
2	smallest of the unsorted part is 12 at index 6	swap index 2 with index 6	[2, 6, 12, 83, 32, 90, 76, 50, 59]	6
3	smallest of the unsorted part is 32 at index 4	swap index 3 with index 4	[2, 6, 12, 32, 83, 90, 76, 50, 59]	5

I	CHOICE	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER THE ITERATION	COMPARISONS
4	smallest of the unsorted part is 50 at index 7	swap index 4 with index 7	[2, 6, 12, 32, 50, 90, 76, 83, 59]	4
5	smallest of the unsorted part is 59 at index 8	swap index 5 with index 8	[2, 6, 12, 32, 50, 59, 76, 83, 90]	3
6	smallest of the unsorted part is 76 at index 6	already in place: no swap	[2, 6, 12, 32, 50, 59, 76, 83, 90]	2
7	smallest of the unsorted part is 83 at index 7	already in place: no swap	[2, 6, 12, 32, 50, 59, 76, 83, 90]	1
Total		6 swaps	sorted	36

36 comparisons (always $n(n - 1) / 2$) and 6 swaps (at most $n - 1 = 8$).

Common mistakes

Sorting / Selection sort · Common mistakes

Common mistakes

1 Storing the minimum value instead of its index.

To swap you need the position. Keep `minIndex`.

2 Starting the scan at `i` instead of `i + 1`.

It still works, because a value compared with itself is never smaller, but it wastes one comparison per iteration and changes your counts.

3 Swapping inside the scan.

Swap *after* the scan finishes, once you know the true minimum. Swapping every time you find a smaller value turns it into a different (and slower) algorithm.

4

Forgetting that the minimum may already be at i .

Then `minIndex == i` and no swap is needed. Counting a swap here gives a wrong total.

5

Running the outer loop to n instead of $n - 1$.

When only one cell is left it is automatically correct, so the last iteration is wasted.

6

Expecting it to stop early on sorted data.

It cannot. All $n(n - 1) / 2$ comparisons are made whatever the input looks like.

7

Calling it stable.

It is not: the long-distance swap can reorder equal values.

8

Using the wrong comparison for descending order.

Select the *maximum* ($>$); do not run the ascending sort and reverse the answer unless the question asks for it.

A test-ready summary

Sorting / Selection sort · A test-ready summary

A test-ready summary

TEST ANSWER

Selection sort is an in-place, comparison-based sorting algorithm that is not stable and not adaptive. It splits the array into a sorted prefix and an unsorted suffix. In each iteration it scans the whole suffix to find the smallest value, remembers its index, and swaps it into the first position of the suffix, so the prefix grows by one final cell. It makes exactly $n(n - 1) / 2$ comparisons whatever the input, but at most $n - 1$ swaps. Its best, average and worst cases are all $O(n^2)$ with $O(1)$ extra space. It is useful for small arrays and when swaps are expensive, but not for large data.

Practice

Sorting / Selection sort · Practice

Practice

Guided question

Use selection sort (ascending) on $[6, 3, 8, 4]$. For each iteration say which value is selected, where it was, and whether a swap happened.

▼ Reveal the guided answer

i = 0: scan indexes 1..3; smallest is 3 at index 1 → swap → $[3, 6, 8, 4]$

i = 1: scan indexes 2..3; smallest is 4 at index 3 → swap → $[3, 4, 8, 6]$

i = 2: scan indexes 3..3; smallest is 6 at index 3 → swap → $[3, 4, 6, 8]$

Totals: 6 comparisons and 3 swaps.

Independent question

Trace selection sort on $[9, 4, 7, 3, 5]$, writing the array after every iteration and the totals.

- For each **i**, find the smallest value in the unsorted part and its index.
- Say whether a swap is needed.
- Write the array after the iteration.
- Total the comparisons (it should be 10 without tracing them) and the swaps.

▼ **Reveal the independent answer**

I	CHOICE	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER THE ITERATION	COMPARISONS
Start	—	—	[9, 4, 7, 3, 5]	—
0	smallest of the unsorted part is 3 at index 3	swap index 0 with index 3	[3, 4, 7, 9, 5]	4
1	smallest of the unsorted part is 4 at index 1	already in place: no swap	[3, 4, 7, 9, 5]	3
2	smallest of the unsorted part is 5 at index 4	swap index 2 with index 4	[3, 4, 5, 9, 7]	2
3	smallest of the unsorted part is 7 at index 4	swap index 3 with index 4	[3, 4, 5, 7, 9]	1
Total		3 swaps	sorted	10

Test-style question

Show the contents of [50, 83, 76, 6, 32, 90, 12, 2, 59] after each iteration when sorting **descending** with selection sort.

▼ **Reveal the test-style answer**

I	CHOICE	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER THE ITERATION	COMPARISONS
Start	—	—	[50, 83, 76, 6, 32, 90, 12, 2, 59]	—

I	CHOICE	ACTION	ARRAY AFTER THE ITERATION	COMPARISONS
0	largest of the unsorted part is 90 at index 5	swap index 0 with index 5	[90, 83, 76, 6, 32, 50, 12, 2, 59]	8
1	largest of the unsorted part is 83 at index 1	already in place: no swap	[90, 83, 76, 6, 32, 50, 12, 2, 59]	7
2	largest of the unsorted part is 76 at index 2	already in place: no swap	[90, 83, 76, 6, 32, 50, 12, 2, 59]	6
3	largest of the unsorted part is 59 at index 8	swap index 3 with index 8	[90, 83, 76, 59, 32, 50, 12, 2, 6]	5
4	largest of the unsorted part is 50 at index 5	swap index 4 with index 5	[90, 83, 76, 59, 50, 32, 12, 2, 6]	4
5	largest of the unsorted part is 32 at index 5	already in place: no swap	[90, 83, 76, 59, 50, 32, 12, 2, 6]	3
6	largest of the unsorted part is 12 at index 6	already in place: no swap	[90, 83, 76, 59, 50, 32, 12, 2, 6]	2
7	largest of the unsorted part is 6 at index 8	swap index 7 with index 8	[90, 83, 76, 59, 50, 32, 12, 6, 2]	1
Total		4 swaps	sorted	36

More worked cases: edge cases, duplicates and descending order

Each case has input and result diagrams, evaluated decisions or merge inputs, exact counts, and a final state.

1. Nearly sorted

1

2

4

3

5

01234

↓ ascending selection sort

1

2

3

4

5

01234

The trace below connects the input diagram to the final result.

PASS	BEFORE	EVALUATED CONDITIONS	AFTER	KEY COMPARISONS
1	[1,2,4,3,5]	2 < 1 → false; best stays 0; 4 < 1 → false; best stays 0; 3 < 1 → false; best stays 0; 5 < 1 → false; best stays 0; Minimum is already in position; no swap.	[1,2,4,3,5]	4
2	[1,2,4,3,5]	4 < 2 → false; best stays 1; 3 < 2 → false; best stays 1; 5 < 2 → false; best stays 1; Minimum is already in position; no swap.	[1,2,4,3,5]	3
3	[1,2,4,3,5]	3 < 4 → true; best index becomes 3; 5 < 3 → false; best stays 3; Scan is complete: swap indexes 2 and 3.	[1,2,3,4,5]	2
4	[1,2,3,4,5]	5 < 4 → false; best stays 3; Minimum is already in position; no swap.	[1,2,3,4,5]	1

10 key comparisons; 1 swaps.

2. Reverse order

5

4

3

2

1

01234

↓ ascending selection sort

1

2

3

4

5

01234

The trace below connects the input diagram to the final result.

PASS	BEFORE	EVALUATED CONDITIONS	AFTER	KEY COMPARISONS
1	[5,4,3,2,1]	4 < 5 → true; best index becomes 1; 3 < 4 → true; best index becomes 2; 2 < 3 → true; best index becomes 3; 1 < 2 → true; best index becomes 4; Scan is complete: swap indexes 0 and 4.	[1,4,3,2,5]	4
2	[1,4,3,2,5]	3 < 4 → true; best index becomes 2; 2 < 3 → true; best index becomes 3; 5 < 2 → false; best stays 3; Scan is complete: swap indexes 1 and 3.	[1,2,3,4,5]	3
3	[1,2,3,4,5]	4 < 3 → false; best stays 2; 5 < 3 → false; best stays 2; Minimum is already in position; no swap.	[1,2,3,4,5]	2
4	[1,2,3,4,5]	5 < 4 → false; best stays 3; Minimum is already in position; no swap.	[1,2,3,4,5]	1

10 key comparisons; 2 swaps.

3. Duplicate values

2

2

1

3

0123

↓ ascending selection sort

1

2

2

3

0123

The trace below connects the input diagram to the final result.

PASS	BEFORE	EVALUATED CONDITIONS	AFTER	KEY COMPARISONS
1	[2,2,1,3]	2 < 2 → false; best stays 0; 1 < 2 → true; best index becomes 2; 3 < 1 → false; best stays 2; Scan is complete: swap indexes 0 and 2.	[1,2,2,3]	3
2	[1,2,2,3]	2 < 2 → false; best stays 1; 3 < 2 → false; best stays 1; Minimum is already in position; no swap.	[1,2,2,3]	2
3	[1,2,2,3]	3 < 2 → false; best stays 2; Minimum is already in position; no swap.	[1,2,2,3]	1

6 key comparisons; 1 swaps.

4. Uneven length

38

27

43

3

9

01234

↓ ascending selection sort

3

9

27

38

43

01234

The trace below connects the input diagram to the final result.

PASS	BEFORE	EVALUATED CONDITIONS	AFTER	KEY COMPARISONS
1	[38,27,43,3,9]	27 < 38 → true; best index becomes 1; 43 < 27 → false; best stays 1; 3 < 27 → true; best index becomes 3; 9 < 3 → false; best stays 3; Scan is complete: swap indexes 0 and 3.	[3,27,43,38,9]	4
2	[3,27,43,38,9]	43 < 27 → false; best stays 1; 38 < 27 → false; best stays 1; 9 < 27 → true; best index becomes 4; Scan is complete: swap indexes 1 and 4.	[3,9,43,38,27]	3
3	[3,9,43,38,27]	38 < 43 → true; best index becomes 3; 27 < 38 → true; best index becomes 4; Scan is complete: swap indexes 2 and 4.	[3,9,27,38,43]	2
4	[3,9,27,38,43]	43 < 38 → false; best stays 3; Minimum is already in position; no swap.	[3,9,27,38,43]	1

10 key comparisons; 3 swaps.

5. Descending target

8

3

5

1

0123

↓ descending selection sort

8

5

3

1

0123

The trace below connects the input diagram to the final result.

PASS	BEFORE	EVALUATED CONDITIONS	AFTER	KEY COMPARISONS
1	[8,3,5,1]	3 > 8 → false; best stays 0; 5 > 8 → false; best stays 0; 1 > 8 → false; best stays 0; Minimum is already in position; no swap.	[8,3,5,1]	3
2	[8,3,5,1]	5 > 3 → true; best index becomes 2; 1 > 5 → false; best stays 2; Scan is complete: swap indexes 1 and 2.	[8,5,3,1]	2
3	[8,5,3,1]	1 > 3 → false; best stays 2; Minimum is already in position; no swap.	[8,5,3,1]	1

6 key comparisons; 1 swaps. Select the maximum instead: change `arr[j] < arr[min]` to `arr[j] > arr[min]`. The prefix then grows in descending order.

Exam-style practice with worked answers

▼ A. Trace [8, 3, 5, 1] in descending order. Show every completed pass/merge. [8]

PASS	BEFORE	AFTER	KEY COMPARISONS
1	[8,3,5,1]	[8,3,5,1]	3
2	[8,3,5,1]	[8,5,3,1]	2
3	[8,5,3,1]	[8,5,3,1]	1

Final result [8,5,3,1]. Select the maximum instead: change $\text{arr}[j] < \text{arr}[\text{min}]$ to $\text{arr}[j] > \text{arr}[\text{min}]$. The prefix then grows in descending order.

▼ B. Explain stability with tagged equal keys. [4]

Swap 1 with 2a in [2a, 2b, 1]: result [1, 2b, 2a]. The equal records crossed, so the taught version is not stable.

▼ C. Give the time and space, then justify both. [5]

Best / average / worst: $O(n^2)$. Every suffix is fully scanned, even on sorted input. Key comparisons: $n(n-1)/2$. Lengths $n-1, n-2, \dots, 1$. Swaps: At most $n-1$. At most one actual exchange per pass; self-swaps are skipped. Auxiliary space: $O(1)$ iterative; $O(n)$ recursive. Only index variables and a temporary value in the iterative form. Stable / in place / adaptive: No / yes / no. A long swap can cross equal records; scanning does not shrink with presortedness.

▼ D. Debug the code before tracing it. [4]

MISTAKE	SYMPTOM	FIX
Set min = arr[i]	Treats a value as an index.	Set min = i, then compare arr[j] and arr[min].
Swap every new minimum immediately	Changes the taught selection procedure and swap counts.	Finish the full scan, then swap once.

▼ E. What happens for [] and [7]? [2]

Both are already sorted. No key comparisons or value movements are required. Merge sort returns at its base case; the iterative methods never enter a pass.